

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Musical, adventure

DIRECTOR

Victor Fleming

WRITERS

Noel Langley, Florence Ryerson, Edgar Allan Woolf (screenplay);
L. Frank Baum (novel)

STARS

Judy Garland, Frank Morgan, Ray Bolger,
Bert Lahr, Jack Haley,
Margaret Hamilton

BEFORE

1938 Judy Garland stars alongside Mickey Rooney in *Love Finds Andy Hardy*.

AFTER

1939 A few months after *The Wizard of Oz*, Fleming's *Gone with the Wind* is released.

1954 Garland stars opposite James Mason in hit musical *A Star Is Born*, her first movie in four troubled years.

Plenty of big movies from the classical Hollywood period have faded into obscurity. Other movies remain respected by the critics, but modern audiences struggle to connect with them. Then there are movies like Victor Fleming's *The Wizard of Oz*, which not only stands the test of time, but continues to entertain. The movie is discovered and embraced by each new generation as passionately as the previous one, and the story has crossed over into a global cultural consciousness. Even if they have never seen the movie, people can sing along to "Somewhere over the Rainbow," and will understand the reference when someone taps their shoes and says "There's no place like home." *The Wizard of Oz* is now more than 70 years old, but it remains a key picture in the making of modern cinema.

A magnificent spectacle

The movie's story sees Dorothy (played by the 17-year-old Judy Garland), a young girl growing up on a Kansas farm, caught in the eye of an impressively rendered twister and magically transported to the Land of Oz. Here, along with a ragtag trio of misfits—

“

I would watch the movie every day when I was two. I had a hard time understanding that I couldn't go *into* the film, because it felt so real to me.

Zooey Deschanel

in the documentary film

These Amazing Shadows, 2011

”

a Scarecrow, a Tin Man, and a Cowardly Lion—she must travel along the Yellow Brick Road, while avoiding the attentions of the Wicked Witch of the West. Her destination is the Emerald City, where the mysterious Wizard of Oz himself resides. The story is probably familiar, but what really sets apart *The Wizard of Oz* is not so much the “what” as the “how”. It is a movie in service of spectacle, a movie that sets out to test the limits of the newly born medium of cinema in every frame.

Minute by minute

00:11

Dorothy runs away from home in Kansas to save her dog Toto from an officious neighbor, Miss Gulch. Professor Marvel, a fortune-teller, persuades her to return.

00:19

The house crashes in Oz, killing the Wicked Witch of the East. The Munchkins celebrate. The Wicked Witch of the West swears revenge.

00:58

The friends arrive at the Emerald City, where the Wizard agrees to grant their wishes if they bring him the Wicked Witch's broom.

01:21

Toto leads the friends to the Castle where they are trapped by the Witch. She sets fire to the Scarecrow. Dorothy throws water, and in doing so melts the Witch.

00:00 00:15 00:30 00:45 01:00 01:15 01:42

00:17

A mighty twister develops, lifting Dorothy's farmhouse into a spin. Miss Gulch on her bicycle is transformed into a witch on a broomstick.

00:34

Dorothy befriends the Scarecrow on the Yellow Brick Road, followed soon after by the Tin Man and the Cowardly Lion.

01:14

In her crystal ball, the Witch watches the friends enter the Haunted Forest. She sends flying monkeys to capture Dorothy.

01:28

Toto exposes the Wizard as a sham. The Good Witch tells Dorothy she can return home by tapping her ruby slippers together.